FREE GUIDE · US

Costco, Aldi & Walmart Cheat Sheet

A free what-to-buy-where list and savings guide, plus a price-check worksheet.

This guide has no store prices on purpose. Prices, brands and stock change by store, region and week. Use the worksheet at the end to write down your own real prices. Nothing here is a promise of savings.

The big idea

No single store is cheapest for everything. A simple rule that works for many people:

- **Aldi** for everyday basics (often smaller packs, store brands, fewer choices).
- **Costco** for things you use a lot and that keep (big packs, if you have room and a membership).
- **Walmart** for the wide selection, one-stop trips, and items the other two don't carry.

Always compare the unit price (price per ounce, per pound or per count) on the shelf tag. The unit price tells you the real deal. A big pack is only cheaper if the unit price is lower **and** you will use it before it spoils.

Aldi: good for basics

What people often look at first (check the unit price at your store):

- Store-brand eggs, milk, butter, bread
- Store-brand pasta, rice, canned beans, canned tomatoes
- Frozen vegetables and frozen fruit
- Oats, peanut butter
- Weekly produce deals

Know before you go

- Bring your own bags (bags usually cost extra) and a quarter for the cart.
- The selection is smaller. Be ready to try the store brand.
- Aldi's weekly "Aldi Finds" are limited stock. Don't buy extras just because they look cheap.
- Store policies change. Ask or check the Aldi app about payment methods and coupons.

Costco: good for staples you really use

Costco needs a paid membership. That cost counts. If you are not sure it saves you money, add up what you would buy in a year before you join. (Check costco.com for the current fee.)

What often makes sense in big packs (if you have fridge and freezer space):

- Rice, dry beans, oats, flour, sugar
- Frozen chicken, frozen vegetables, frozen fruit
- Eggs, butter, cheese
- Olive oil and cooking oil
- Toilet paper, paper towels, laundry detergent (non-food)

Traps to avoid

- Don't buy more fresh food than you can eat. Wasted food erases the savings.
- Don't buy snacks and treats "because it's a deal" if you wouldn't buy them anyway.
- Split big packs with a friend or family member if you only cook for 1–2.

Walmart: good for one-stop trips

Often useful for

- Pantry basics when you can't get to Aldi or Costco
- Cheaper store brand (Great Value) staples. Compare the unit price.
- Items other stores don't have (specific brands, spices, household items)
- Walmart app: check prices and use pickup if it helps you avoid impulse buys

Know before you go

- Prices can differ from store to store and between the app and the shelf.

- Pickup and delivery can have fees or minimums. Check them before you order.
- Walmart accepts some manufacturer coupons in store. Check the store's current coupon policy.

A simple 3-store plan (for 1–2 people)

What	Where to look first
Eggs, bread, milk, canned goods	Aldi or Walmart (compare unit price)
Rice, beans, oats in bulk	Costco or Walmart
Frozen chicken and frozen veg	Aldi or Costco
Fresh produce	Whichever has the best weekly sale
Spices and specialty items	Walmart or an ethnic grocery store
Household paper goods	Costco or Walmart

This table is a starting point, not a rule. Write down what you really find in the worksheet.

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7 habits that save money at any store

1. **Shop with a written list.** Check your pantry and fridge first.
2. **Never shop hungry.** Impulse buys add up fast.
3. **Read the unit price,** not the big sticker price.
4. **Try store brands** for staples like rice, pasta, beans, flour and frozen vegetables.
5. **Buy produce that's in season** and on sale. Frozen is fine too.
6. **Check the store app** for digital coupons before you shop (free).
7. **Plan meals around what is on sale,** not the other way around.

The 2-store price check (10 minutes, once)

1. Pick 10 things you buy every week.
2. At each store (or on its app), write down the unit price for each one.
3. Circle the lowest unit price for each item.
4. Next time, buy each item where it was lowest, **if** the extra trip is worth your time and gas.

Tip: if a second store trip costs gas and time, one well-planned store per week may beat three stores.

Price worksheet (fill in with your real prices)

Item	Aldi (unit price)	Costco (unit price)	Walmart (unit price)	Best
Eggs				
Rice				
Dry or canned beans				
Pasta				
Oats				
Chicken (per lb)				
Frozen vegetables				
Bread				
Milk				
Cooking oil				

Made for the community. Share it with a friend who is watching their budget.